

SCAMPER

Substitute · Combine · Adapt · Modify · Put to other use · Eliminate · Reverse

PROFESSIONAL DEFINITION

SCAMPER is a checklist of seven idea-triggering verbs applied to an existing product, service or process to force new variations: **S**ubstitute, **C**ombine, **A**dapt, **M**odify (magnify/minify), **P**ut to other use, **E**liminate and **R**everse. Each prompt deliberately disrupts assumptions to generate fresh options.

WHO DEVELOPED IT

The underlying question list originated with Alex Osborn (1953); it was organised into the SCAMPER mnemonic by educator Bob Eberle in 1971.

WHY IT WAS DEVELOPED

Unstructured brainstorming often stalls because people run out of directions to think in. SCAMPER supplies ready-made angles of attack so a group can keep generating when inspiration runs dry.

HOW IT IS USED

Take a target (the thing to improve), then work through each verb in turn, writing down every idea it triggers without judging. The technique is deliberately mechanical — quantity first, evaluation later.

WHEN IT IS USED

During the ideation phase, especially for incremental innovation on existing offerings, or as a warm-up to loosen thinking before divergent work.

BY WHOM IT IS USED

Product teams, marketers, facilitators and students learning structured ideation.

FIGURE 1 · SEVEN IDEA TRIGGERS

S	Substitute	swap a part, material or person
C	Combine	merge functions or ideas
A	Adapt	borrow a solution from elsewhere
M	Modify	magnify, minify, change form
P	Put to other use	new users, new contexts
E	Eliminate	remove, simplify, strip back
R	Reverse	rearrange, invert the order

Figure 1. The seven SCAMPER verbs, applied one at a time to an existing product, service or process.

INNOVATION RELATIVE TO PRIOR PRACTICE

Unlike open brainstorming, SCAMPER **guarantees coverage** of distinct transformation types, so teams don't fixate on a single direction. It converts Osborn's principles into a fast, repeatable tool.

RELATED FRAMEWORKS IN THIS COURSE

Brainstorming *Slibrary 7*

Worst Possible Idea *Slibrary 7*

Six Thinking Hats *Slibrary 2*

SOURCES (HARVARD · CITE THEM RIGHT)

Eberle, B. (1971) *SCAMPER: Games for Imagination Development*. Buffalo, NY: DOK.

Osborn, A.F. (1953) *Applied Imagination*. New York: Scribner.